

Houston - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-40 baseline with Top-25 upside, but meaningful regression risk from a 10-win record that was stronger than the underlying efficiency profile.
Preseason consensus	No. 23 (252 points) · No. 38
Returning production	65% (No. 15) overall · Off. 71% (No. 7) · Def. 58% (No. 47)
Primer power rating	+7.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.4 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ - Similar underlying quality, with a stronger offensive ceiling and lower defensive continuity
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Houston should build around returning QB Conner Weigman, featured RB Makhi Hughes, WR Amare Thomas and WR Trent Walker behind a talented but transfer-heavy offensive line.

Bottom line: Houston has enough returning quarterback/receiver quality and incoming offensive talent to remain dangerous, but the safest baseline is closer to SP+ No. 38 than AP No. 23 until a transfer-heavy OL and rebuilt veteran defense prove last year's 10-win result is repeatable.

Beats expectations if: OL Shadre Hurst/C Anthony Boswell and the new line gel quickly, RB Makhi Hughes gives QB Conner Weigman a reliable run-game partner, and WR Amare Thomas/WR Trent Walker form a high-end tandem.

Disappoints if: The 10-win record proves more durable in reputation than in underlying performance, the new OL/TE/RB combinations fail to improve a No. 94 offensive success-rate profile, and the defense cannot replace its NFL-bound interior and secondary experience.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Conner Weigman is the returning QB1; recent throwing-rest days were load management, not a new injury diagnosis.
- 2 Offensive line:** Houston returns 71% of offensive production (No. 7), but the projected starting OL still includes three transfer starters.
- 3 Receiver room:** WR Amare Thomas returns after a 966-yard, 12-TD season and is joined by transfer WR Trent Walker.
- 4 Defensive front:** The defense loses a major veteran class, including DL Carlos Allen Jr., DL Eddie Walls III and multiple experienced defensive backs.
- 5 Late roster update:** WR Stephon Johnson has regained eligibility and rejoined Houston; K Ethan Sanchez remains outside the current 2026 roster picture.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	10-3 (6-3 Big 12)	● Excellent
Scoring	29.1 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	394.5 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	178.1 YPG · 4.2 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	7.46 YPA · 26 TD / 10 INT	● Good / above average
Third downs	41.0%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	22.8 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	347.8 YPG allowed	● Good / above average
Rush defense	129.0 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	218.8 YPG · 7.06 YPA · 16 TD allowed	● Good / above average

Houston's traditional profile was solid but not dominant: No. 55 scoring offense, No. 61 total offense and No. 39 rushing offense; the defense sat No. 47 in both scoring and total defense and No. 38 against the run. The 10-win record therefore came without an obvious elite full-unit statistical signature.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+1.62 · No. 57	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.036 · No. 52	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	41.1% · No. 94	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.8% · No. 75	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	13.1% · No. 32	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+1.30 · No. 55	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.066 · No. 40	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	41.9% · No. 73	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.9% · No. 43	● Good / above average
Havoc created	16.7% · No. 42	● Good / above average

Advanced-stat read: Houston's 10-3 record outpaced an underlying profile that was mostly average: opponent-adjusted offense No. 57, opponent-adjusted defense No. 55 and offensive success rate No. 94.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Willie Fritz - returning	● ↔ Program identity and operating structure remain stable under Willie Fritz.
OC	Slade Nagle - returning coordinator; game-day play-calling authority unresolved	● ↔ Offensive-system continuity helps, but game-day play-calling authority remains unresolved.
DC	Austin Armstrong - returning coordinator; game-day play-calling authority unresolved	● ↔ Defensive-system continuity helps, with game-day calling responsibility still unresolved.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Makhi Hughes	Oregon	● ↔ Projected primary back with Doak Walker recognition, replacing much of RB Dean Connors' 2025 workload.
◆ WR Trent Walker	Oregon State	● ↑ Adds proven major receiving production (1,700+ yards over his prior two Oregon State seasons).
WR Stephon Johnson	Eligibility restored / returning to Houston	● ↔ Late return adds experienced receiver depth, though readiness after the delayed reinstatement remains a monitor.
◆ OL Shadre Hurst	Tulane	● ↑ Expected starting guard with AP preseason first-team, Big 12 first-team and Outland recognition.
◆ C Anthony Boswell	Toledo	● ↔ Likely starting center with Rimington recognition, but line cohesion remains a projection.
◆ TE Patrick Overmyer	UTSA	● ↔ Productive transfer and Mackey watch-list selection who helps replace NFL-drafted TE Tanner Koziol.

Out	To	Loss
TE Tanner Koziol	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 5, No. 164	● ↓ A 74-catch All-America/Mackey semifinalist is a major proven receiving loss.
RB Dean Connors	NFL (L.A. Rams), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 977-yard lead rusher departs, creating a major workload replacement.
OL Demetrius Hunter	Colorado	● ↓ Two-year OL starter leaves, increasing the importance of immediate transfer-line cohesion.
OL Matthew Wykoff	eligibility/graduation	● ↓ An 11-start 2025 guard leaves, reducing proven OL continuity.
WR/RET Mekhi Mews	CFL (Montreal)	● ↔ Material receiver/return specialist leaves for a confirmed CFL destination; offense has replacement receiver talent.

Offensive net: ● ↑ Modest upgrade ceiling with real cohesion risk

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Ashton Porter	Oregon	● ↔ Major front role addition.
◆ LB Jaden Yates	Ole Miss	● ↔ Experienced backup/sub-package candidate with nine Ole Miss starts in 2025.
◆ DB Javion White	Tulane	● ↔ Projected STAR/nickel player after a three-interception, six-PBU season at Tulane.
◆ DB Jalen Mayo	Stephen F. Austin	● ↔ Four-interception SFA transfer competing for a major corner role; hamstring limitation was precautionary.

Out	To	Loss
DL Carlos Allen Jr.	NFL (Atlanta), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Led FBS interior linemen with 80 tackles and leaves on a confirmed NFL contract.
DL Eddie Walls III	NFL (L.A. Rams), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Houston's 11.5-TFL leader leaves on a confirmed NFL contract.
DB Latrell McCutchin Sr.	NFL (Tennessee), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material starting corner departs on a confirmed NFL contract.
DB Zelmar Vedder	NFL (Kansas City), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful veteran defensive back leaves on a confirmed NFL contract.
DB Wrook Brown	eligibility/graduation	● ↓ Significant senior DB leaves, reducing veteran secondary continuity.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Likely step back in continuity and proven production

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	An experienced-QB offense built around QB Conner Weigman.	QB stability, top-end WR talent and individual OL quality stand out; Houston also ranked No. 32 nationally in havoc allowed in 2025.	The 2025 offense ranked No. 94 in success rate, and three transfer OL starters plus new lead RB/TE roles create cohesion risk.
Defense	A returning Armstrong-coordinated structure using two linebackers and a STAR/nickel role.	CB Will James, DL Khalil Laufau and Brandon Mack II give the defense high-value returning pieces.	The unit loses two major interior NFL players plus multiple veteran defensive backs.
Special teams	Transition unit with an open kicker competition and turnover at long snapper/return specialist.	Dimas is a current front-runner rather than a completely undefined competition.	No winner is final, Sanchez cannot be counted as a return.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB Conner Weigman returns as a 13-game starter and current QB1 with Maxwell recognition.
RB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Makhi Hughes is the projected lead back after RB Dean Connors' 977-yard departure.
WR	● A-	● ↑	Medium-high	WR Amare Thomas returns after 966 yards/12 TDs and WR Trent Walker adds major proven production.
TE	● B	● ↓	Medium	TE Patrick Overmyer is productive/Mackey-recognized but replaces 74-catch TE Tanner Koziol.
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium	OL Shadre Hurst/C Anthony Boswell and a transfer-heavy projected five offer talent with cohesion risk.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	DL Khalil Laufau and transfer depth lead a front replacing DL Carlos Allen Jr./DL Eddie Walls III.
LB	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Returning starters and LB Jaden Yates provide functional depth without a clear high-end anchor.
Secondary	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Will James anchors a reworked secondary after multiple veteran departures.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	SP+ ranks the unit No. 101, with kicker and return roles still changing.
Coaching	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Willie Fritz, OC Slade Nagle and DC Austin Armstrong return, preserving system continuity.
Overall	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	SP+ No. 38 fits an above-average Power Four/top-45 baseline.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Amare Thomas	WR	● National-level conference star	Big 12 Preseason Team: first team · Biletnikoff Award	Returns after 966 yards and 12 TDs as the offense's safest proven skill centerpiece.
◆ Shadre Hurst (TR: Tulane)	OL	● National star / elite guard projection	AP preseason first team · Big 12 Preseason Team: first team · Outland Trophy	The highest-recognition individual on the roster.
Will James	CB	● High-end conference star	Big 12 Preseason Team: first team · Bednarik Award · Bronko Nagurski Trophy	Primary returning secondary anchor after multiple veteran DB departures.
Conner Weigman	QB	● High-end conference starter	Maxwell Award	Returning 13-game starter and the continuity point around which the rebuilt offense is organized.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Makhi Hughes (TR: Oregon)	RB	● Projected high-end Power Four starter	Doak Walker Award	Primary incoming back expected to replace Dean Connors' 977-yard production.
◆ Trent Walker (TR: Oregon State)	WR	● High-end conference starter	Biletnikoff Award	Adds 1,700+ receiving yards over his prior two Oregon State seasons next to Thomas.
◆ Patrick Overmyer (TR: UTSA)	TE	● Solid-to-high-end Power Four starter	John Mackey Award	Productive transfer with 59 catches.
Khalil Laufau	DL	● High-end conference starter	Outland Trophy	Returning interior anchor whose value rises because the unit loses Carlos Allen.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderate overall, with one major road mismatch at Texas Tech and a pivotal midseason three-game Big 12 stretch before the bye.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 57
Hardest stretch	at Kansas State -> Oklahoma State -> at Utah
Swing games	at Kansas State, Oklahoma State, at Utah, at Colorado, Baylor
Advantage	The bye comes immediately after the Kansas State/Oklahoma State/Utah run, and the final four games do not include a top-50 SP+ opponent.
Expected	7.4 wins; likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The combination of a 10-3 record and AP No. 23 ranking may price Houston closer to a stable top-25 team than SP+ No. 38 supports. The key interpretive question is whether 2025 established a new program baseline or represented a close-game high-water mark.
Back them when	When priced near the top-40 model baseline and the matchup lets QB Weigman distribute to WR Thomas/WR Walker behind a settled OL.
Fade/pass when	When the market carries forward the 10-win/AP ranking premium into games against strong fronts.
Key monitor	projected OL five and early cohesion, Stephon Johnson's readiness after his late return, Muizz Tounkara and Luke McGary opener availability, kicker winner, DB Jalen Mayo/Keany Parks health, replacement production for Carlos Allen/Eddie Walls and veteran DB exits.
Week 1 baseline	vs. Oregon State: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Houston -20.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Houston's upside is offensive: QB Conner Weigman returns, WR Amare Thomas/WR Trent Walker can form a high-end tandem, and RB Makhi Hughes plus a talented transfer OL give the Cougars more ceiling than their mostly average 2025 efficiency profile showed. Staff continuity under Willie Fritz also reduces transition risk.

The caution is that **10-3** outpaced the underlying numbers and the defense loses substantial veteran production. Until the new OL and rebuilt front/secondary prove stable, **SP+ No. 38** is a safer baseline than the AP No. 23 label, with **7.4 wins / 7-5** the preseason center.

About this primer

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